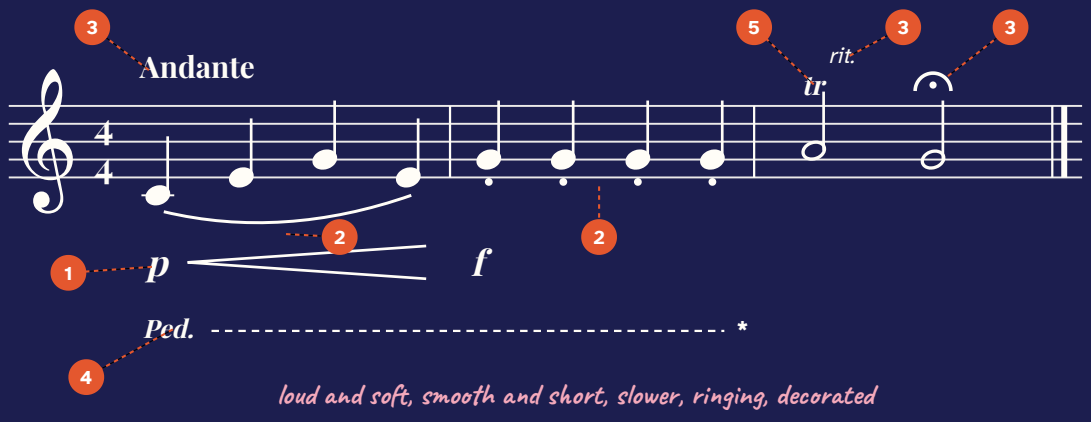
PART III · HOW IT SHOULD SOUND

Expression

The notes say **what** to play; expression says **how**: loud or soft, smooth or short, faster or slower, ringing or dry. Everything in this part is in these three bars.



1 **Loud and soft** p. 76
p, f and the steps between; hairpins grow and fade

2 **Touch: smooth, short, strong** p. 79
slurs, staccato dots, tenuto lines and accents

3 **Speed words** p. 82
Andante, Allegro; rit. slows down, a fermata waits

4 **The pedals** p. 85
Ped. down, * up: the right pedal keeps notes ringing

5 **Ornaments** p. 88
trills, mordents, turns and grace notes

★ **Tips: when your playing sounds flat** p. 91

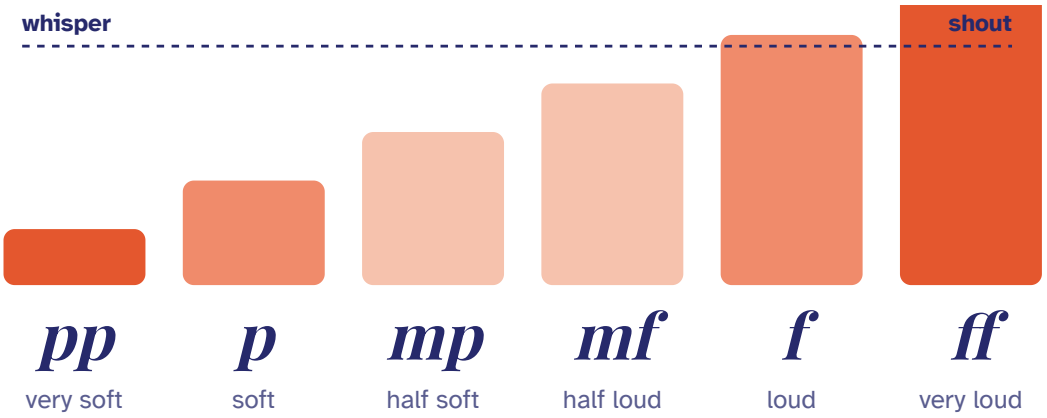
PART III · EXPRESSION · 1

Loud and soft

A voice can whisper, chat or shout. Music does the same, and small Italian words tell you which: the **dynamics**. They sit under the notes, shortened to one or two letters.

THE SECRET

Six steps, from a whisper to a shout: pp p mp mf f ff. m means half.



Six steps from a whisper to a shout
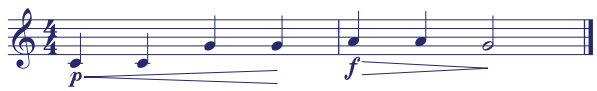
SIGN	SAY IT	HOW IT SOUNDS
pp	**pianissimo**	very soft
p	**piano**	soft
mp	**mezzo-piano**	half soft: a little louder than *p*
mf	**mezzo-forte**	half loud: a little softer than *f*
f	**forte**	loud
ff	**fortissimo**	very loud

THE RULE

p is soft, f is loud; m (mezzo) means half; a second letter means very. A sign lasts until the next one.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 1 · CONTINUED

Growing and fading



A hairpin that opens grows louder; one that closes fades. From *p* to *f* and back.



The same idea in words: *cresc.* and dashes, then *ff*.

SIGN	NAME	WHAT YOU DO
	**crescendo** (*cresc.*)	getting louder, little by little
	**diminuendo** (*dim.*, *decresc.*)	getting softer, little by little
sfz* / *sf	**sforzando**	one note made suddenly strong
fp	**forte-piano**	loud, then soft at once
subito p	**subito**	“suddenly”: *subito p*, suddenly soft

EXAMPLE 1

Which is louder: mp or mf?
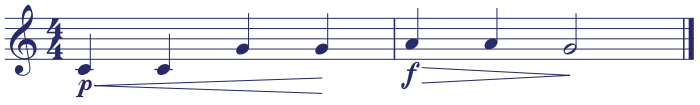
mp ***mf*** ?

1. **m means half.** Half of what?
2. **p is soft, f is loud.**
3. **So which half** is louder?

mf, half loud, is louder than **mp**, half soft. Both sit in the middle of the ladder.

EXAMPLE 2

What happens across the hairpins?



?

1. **Find the start:** which sign?
2. **The first hairpin opens** to which sign?
3. **The second hairpin closes.** What happens?

Start *p*, grow through bar 1 into *f*, then **fade** through bar 2.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

pp → ***ff***
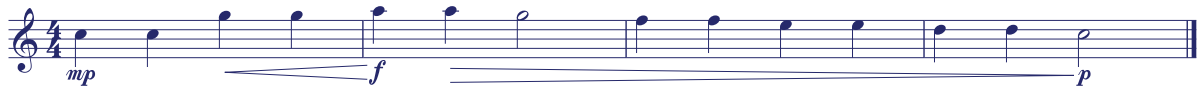
One note, six ways.

Play Middle C *pp*, then *p*, *mp*, *mf*, *f*, *ff*. Six different steps? Then come back down.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 1 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Where is the loudest note?



?

1. **Start:** *mp*.
2. **Follow the hairpin** to its sign.
3. **Then the long hairpin closes** to which sign?

The **first A in bar 2**, at *f*. From the next note the tune fades all the way to *p*.

GAME

Soft to loud

1	2	3	4	5	6
mf	*pp*	*f*	*p*	*ff*	*mp*

Put the six signs in order from the softest to the loudest.

Answer: pp · p · mp · mf · f · ff.
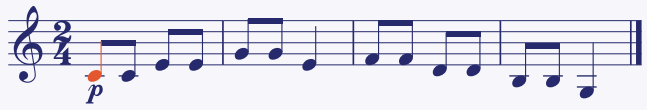
HOW TO

Practise a crescendo

1. **Play five notes up**, C to G, all *p*.
2. **Now grow** one step on each note: *p* to *f*.
3. **Come back down** the same notes, fading to *p*, without slowing down.

YOU KNOW THIS

Haydn's "Surprise" Symphony



The tune tiptoes along softly, then comes again even softer, *pp*. Just as everyone relaxes, the whole orchestra crashes in with one **ff** chord: the surprise that gave the symphony its name.

Try it. Hum it very softly, then clap once, as loud as you can.

THINK OF IT Dynamics are a volume knob with six clicks. Turn it with the weight of your arm, not by hitting harder.

TRAP

- × Playing everything *mf*: each sign is a different step.
- × Speeding up in a crescendo: louder is not faster.

SEE ALSO

Touch p. 79 · Pulse and tempo p. 50

PRACTISE IT

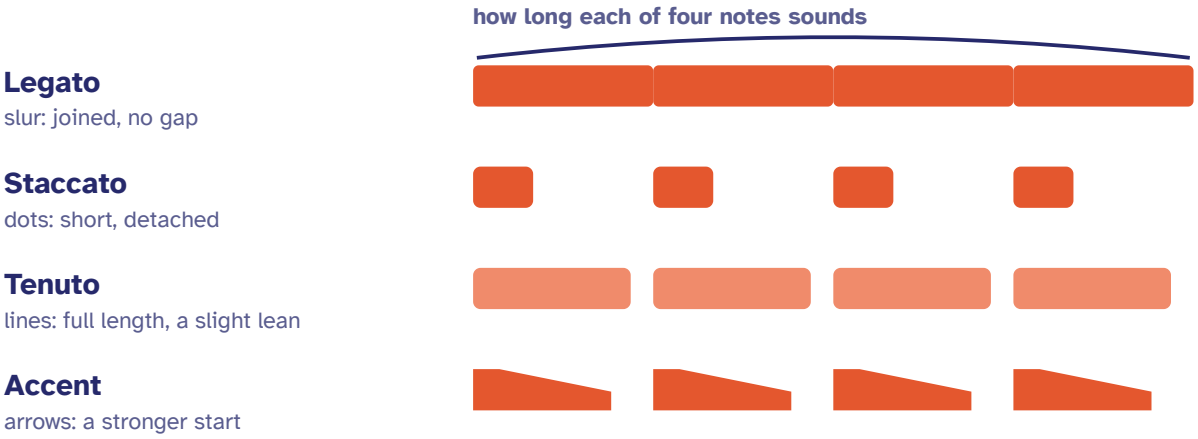
Online: Library › Dynamics

PART III · EXPRESSION · 2
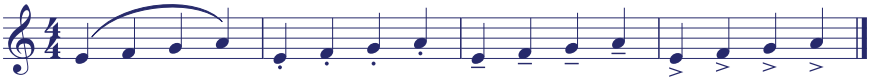
Touch: smooth, short, strong

The same four notes can sound smooth or bouncy, gentle or strong. Small marks above or below the notes tell your fingers how to touch the keys: this is **articulation**.

THE SECRET
Curve: join. Dot: short.
Line: hold. Arrow: strong.
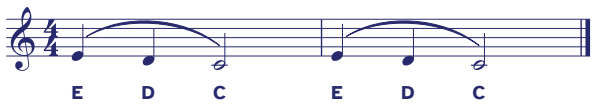


Same notes, four touches
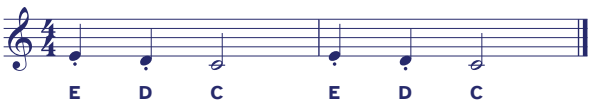


The same four notes: slurred, staccato, tenuto, accented.

MARK	NAME	HOW TO PLAY
⌒	**slur** (*legato*)	join the notes smoothly, no gap
●	**staccato**	short and detached: let go early
—	**tenuto**	hold the full length, leaning a little
>	**accent**	a stronger start to the note
▼	**staccatissimo**	very short *Extra*
^	**marcato**	very strong, marked *Extra*

Slurs and phrases



Slurred: join E D C, then a tiny lift.
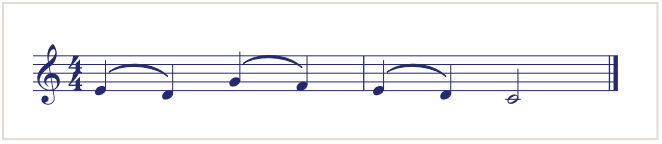


Staccato: every E and D let go early.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 2 · CONTINUED

A curve over **different** notes is a slur: join them, then lift at its end, like a breath. A long slur over a whole line of tune is a **phrase mark**: one musical sentence. (A curve joining the **same** note twice is a tie, p. 56.)

Two-note slurs



A slur over just two notes is a little sigh: **drop** into the first note, then **lift** off the second, lighter and a little shorter. Drop, lift.
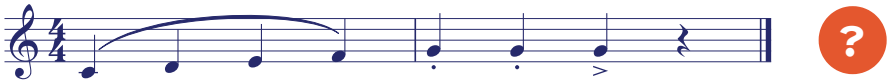
Mood words

Some words describe the mood, not the speed.

WORD	MEANING	WORD	MEANING
dolce	sweetly	*leggiero*	lightly
cantabile	in a singing style	*espressivo*	with feeling
legato	smoothly	*grazioso*	gracefully
maestoso	majestically	*con moto*	with movement

EXAMPLE 1

Which notes are short?
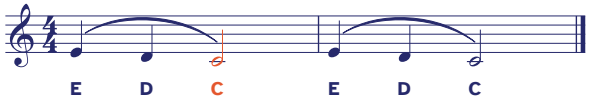


1. **Bar 1:** what does the curve ask?
2. **Bar 2:** find the dots.
3. **The last G** has a different mark: which?

Bar 1 is joined; the **two dotted Gs are short**; the third G is accented, stronger but full length.

EXAMPLE 2

How do you play the end of a slur?



1. **Join E D C** under the first curve.
2. **At the end of the curve:** hold, or lift?
3. **The next curve** starts on E again.

Join the notes, then **lift after the C**: a small breath before the next E, like a singer.

HOW TO
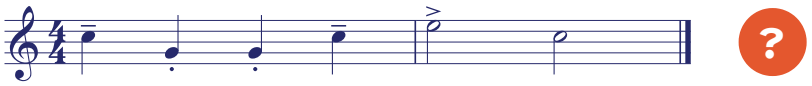
Practise touch

1. **Play one bar** of a piece three ways: all legato, all staccato, then as written.
2. **Listen:** can someone else hear which way was which?

PART III · EXPRESSION · 2 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Line, dot or arrow?



1. **The first two Cs have lines:** how long?
2. **The Gs have dots.**
3. **The E in bar 2** has an arrow.

The first two Cs held their **full length**, the Gs short, the E strong, and the last C plain, held for its two beats.

GAME
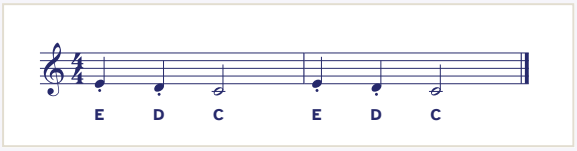
Name the touch

1	2	3	4
a dot	a line	>	a long curve

Name each mark and say how the note sounds.

Answer: 1 staccato, short · 2 tenuto, full and leaning · 3 accent, a strong start · 4 slur, joined (over different notes).

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
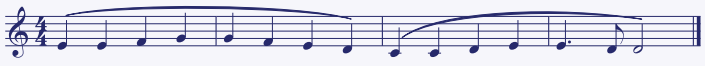


Hot Cross Buns, two ways.

Play E D C joined (fingers 3 2 1), then short and bouncy. Same notes, same fingers: two different tunes.

YOU KNOW THIS

Ode to Joy (Beethoven)



Two long slurs: two musical sentences. Lift your hand **only** at the end of each one, like a singer taking a breath.

Try it. Sing it and breathe only where the slurs end.

THINK OF IT Legato is walking: one foot leaves the ground as the other lands. Staccato is hopping on hot sand.

TRAP

- × Making staccato loud: short is not the same as strong.
- × Lifting in the middle of a slur: keep every note joined until the curve ends.

SEE ALSO

Loud and soft p. 76 · Tie or slur? p. 57

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Articulation

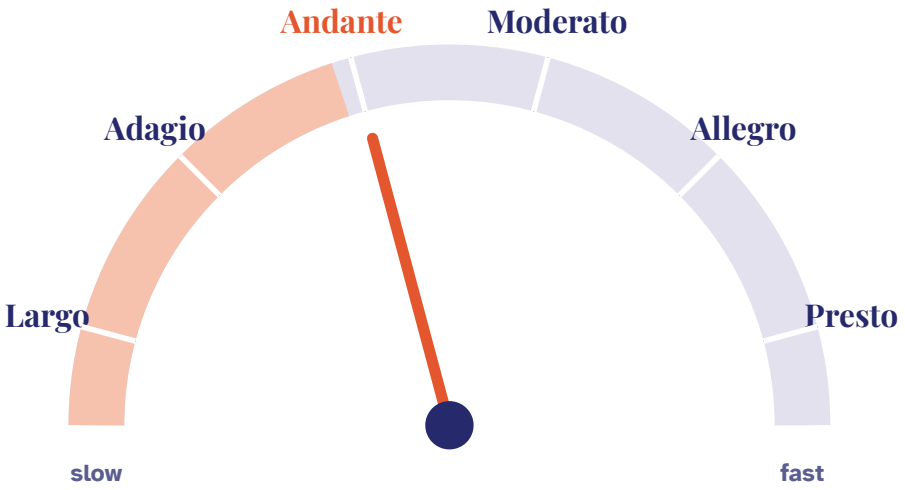
PART III · EXPRESSION · 3

Speed words

How fast is the beat? A word at the top of the music tells you, usually in Italian, and often a number too. Other words inside the music ask you to slow down, speed up, or wait.

THE SECRET

The word at the top sets the speed; rit. brakes gently, a tempo drives off again.



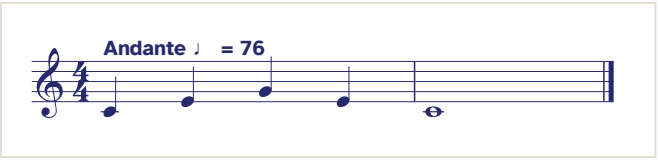
Andante: the speed of walking

WORD	MEANING	ABOUT (BEATS A MINUTE)
Largo	very slow and broad	40–60
Lento	slow	45–60
Adagio	slow, at ease	60–76
Andante	at a walking pace	76–108
Moderato	at a moderate speed	108–120
Allegretto	fairly fast, a little slower than Allegro	100–120
Allegro	fast and lively	120–156
Vivace	lively and brisk	152–168
Presto	very fast	168–200

The numbers are a rough guide: the music and the room decide the rest.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 3 · CONTINUED

The metronome mark
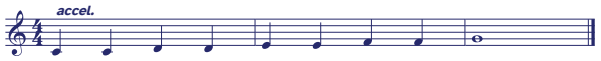


♩ **= 76** means 76 crotchet beats in one minute. Set a metronome to 76: each click is one beat. The word tells you the character; the number pins down the speed.

Changing speed

WORD OR SIGN	WHAT YOU DO
rit. (ritardando), *rall.* (rallentando)	gradually slower
accel. (accelerando)	gradually faster
a tempo	back to the speed before
𝄐 fermata (pause)	hold longer than written, then go on
poco a poco	little by little
molto · *poco* · *più* · *meno*	very · a little · more · less (*più mosso*: faster; *meno mosso*: slower)
rubato	time borrowed and paid back (p. 69) *Extra*



rit.: slow down into the end, then wait on the fermata.



accel.: speed up, little by little, to the end.

EXAMPLE 1

How fast is ♩ = 60?
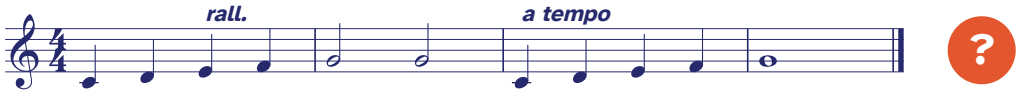
♩ = 60 ?

1. **60 beats** in one minute.
2. **How many seconds** are there in a minute?
3. **So one beat** lasts how long?

One beat every **second**: tick, tick, like a clock.

EXAMPLE 2

Where does it slow down, and where does it come back?
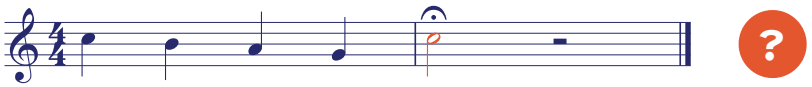


?

1. **Find rall.** Which notes does it slow?
2. **Find a tempo.**
3. **What speed** does a tempo mean?

Bar 1 slows into the two Gs; at **a tempo** (bar 3) the first speed comes straight back.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 3 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

How long do you hold the fermata?



1. **The minim** is worth how many beats?
2. **The fermata** asks for more. How much?
3. **Then what?**

Longer than 2 beats: hold until it **feels finished**, often half as long again or more, then go on.

GAME

Slow to fast

1	2	3	4
Allegro	Largo	Andante	Presto

Put the four words in order from the slowest to the fastest.

Answer: Largo · Andante · Allegro · Presto.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS
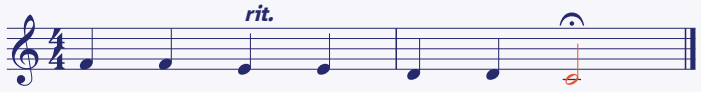
Andante

Walk it.

Walk across the room at a calm pace, saying 1 2 3 4 with your steps: that is Andante. Now jog on the spot: Allegro.

YOU KNOW THIS

Twinkle, Twinkle, Little Star



Players often slow down into the last “are”: a **rit.**, then a fermata on the final C. The ending feels like coming home.

Try it. Sing the last line twice: once in time, once with a rit.

THINK OF IT A rit. is a car braking gently at the lights; a tempo is driving off again at the same speed as before.

TRAP

- × Taking Andante as slow: it is a walking pace.
- × Slowing down all at once at rit.: slow little by little.
- × Forgetting a tempo: after a rit., the first speed comes back exactly.

SEE ALSO

Pulse and tempo p. 50 · Rubato p. 69

PRACTISE IT

Online: Metronome

PART III · EXPRESSION · 4

The pedals

Most pianos have three pedals. The right one, the **sustain pedal**, lifts every damper off the strings, so notes keep ringing after your fingers let go. The left one makes the sound softer.

THE SECRET

Play first, then change the pedal: up and straight down again.



soft pedal
una corda
softer, gentler

middle pedal
sostenuto
holds only some notes

sustain pedal
damper pedal
notes keep ringing

Right pedal: the notes keep ringing

PEDAL	NAME AND SIGN	WHAT IT DOES
left	soft pedal: *una corda*, written *u.c.*	a softer, gentler sound; lift it at *t.c.* (*tre corde*)
middle	*sostenuto* *Extra*	holds only the notes already down (on many uprights: a practice mute)
right	sustain (damper) pedal: *Ped.*	every note keeps ringing until you lift it

Writing the sustain pedal

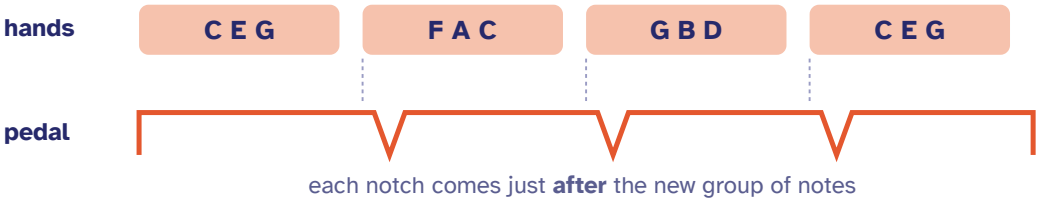


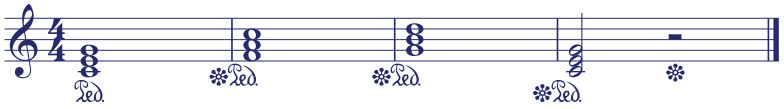
THE RULE

Heel on the floor, press with the ball of your foot. Play first, then pedal: new notes, then up and straight down again.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 4 · CONTINUED

Changing the pedal





A chord is three or more notes played together. The ✻Ped. sits under each new chord: play it first, then change straight away.
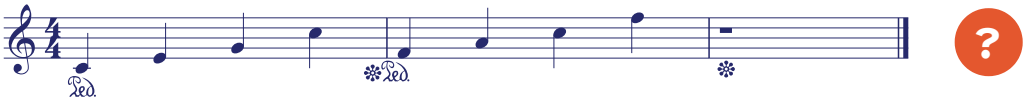
EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Half pedal and the middle pedal

Half pedal: lift the pedal only part of the way, to clear some of the sound but not all. **Sostenuto** (the middle pedal on grand pianos): press it while notes are held, and only those notes keep ringing.

EXAMPLE 1

Where does the pedal go down, and where does it come up?
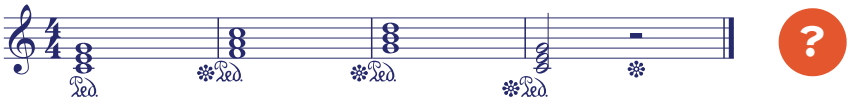


1. **Find Ped.** under the first C.
2. **Find the next sign:** a star with Ped.
3. **Find the last star.**

Down on the first C, **changed** at the first F (up and down again), and up at the end: each bar rings as one sound.

EXAMPLE 2

Why change at every new chord?



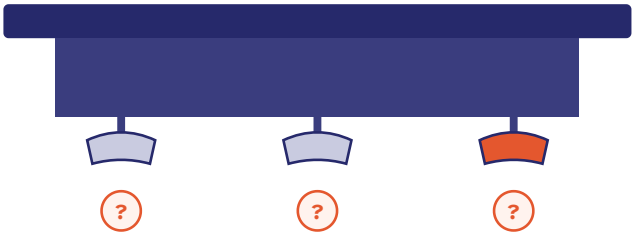
1. **Hold the pedal** from C-E-G into F-A-C. What do you hear?
2. **Now change** just after the F.
3. **Compare** the two.

Without a change, the two groups **blur** into a muddle. Change on each new chord: clean, and still joined.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 3

Which pedal?



1 **Ped.**: which foot pedal? 2 **u.c.**: which one? 3 **t.c.**: what do you do?

Ped. is the **right** pedal; *u.c.* the **left** one; *t.c.* means let the left pedal up.

GAME
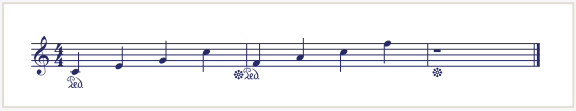
Up or down?

1	2	3	4
Ped.	*	u.c.	t.c.

Which pedal, and up or down?

Answer: 1 right pedal down · 2 right pedal up · 3 left pedal down · 4 left pedal up.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



Hear the ringing.

Play C, E and G together, press the right pedal and take your hands off: the chord keeps sounding. Lift the pedal: silence.

HOW TO

Practise the pedal change

1. **Without playing**, say “play, up-down” and move your foot on “up-down”.
2. **Play C-E-G, then F-A-C, then G-B-D**, slowly. Change just after each one.
3. **Listen** for a clean change with no gap of silence.

THINK OF IT The sustain pedal holds a door open: every note that walks in stays in the room until you let the door shut.

TRAP

- × Lifting the pedal before the new notes: a gap of silence. Play first, then change.
- × Keeping the pedal down through a new chord: muddy.

SEE ALSO
Touch p. 79 · Chords p. 110

PRACTISE IT
Online: Library › Pedal

PART III · EXPRESSION · 5

Ornaments
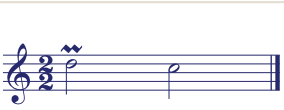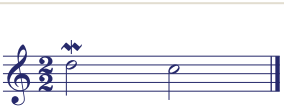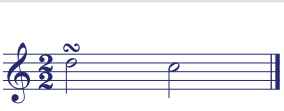
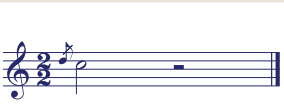
Ornaments are decorations: a small sign that stands for a quick burst of notes around the main note. They borrow the notes **next door**, one letter name up or down: on D, the note above is E and the note below is C.

THE SECRET

An ornament is a necklace on the note: it borrows the next-door notes, and the main note still lands on time.
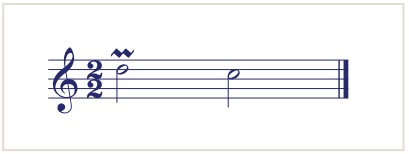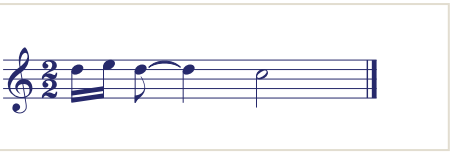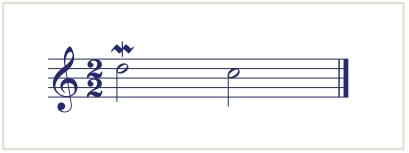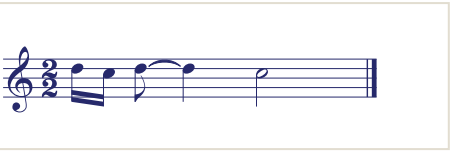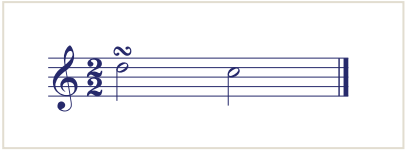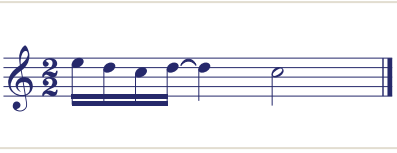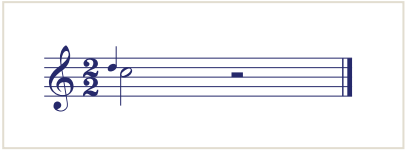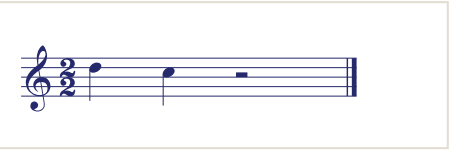


A small sign, a burst of notes

WRITTEN	NAME	HOW TO PLAY
	**trill**	the note and the one above, back and forth quickly
	**upper mordent**	the note, the one above, the note: one quick flick
	**lower mordent**	the note, the one below, the note
	**turn**	above, the note, below, the note
	**acciaccatura**	a tiny note with a slash: crushed in, as fast as you can
	**appoggiatura**	a tiny note, no slash: leans, taking half the main note's time

PART III · EXPRESSION · 5 · CONTINUED

Written and played

	WRITTEN		PLAYED
upper mordent		→	
lower mordent		→	
turn		→	
appoggiatura		→	

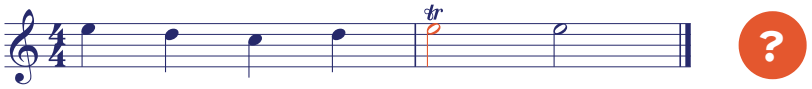
EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Where does a trill start?

In music from the 1700s (Bach, Handel), a trill usually starts on the note **above**: F E F E on an E. In later music it starts on the main note. Your teacher or the edition will tell you.

EXAMPLE 1

How do you play this trill?



?

1. **Which note** has the tr?
2. **Its next-door note above** is...?
3. **Go back and forth** for how long?

On the E: **E F E F...** quickly for its two beats, then the last E on time.

GAME

Above or below?

1	2	3	4
trill	upper mordent	lower mordent	turn

Which next-door note does each one use: above, below, or both?

Answer: 1 above · 2 above · 3 below · 4 both.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 5 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 2

Crushed, or leaning?
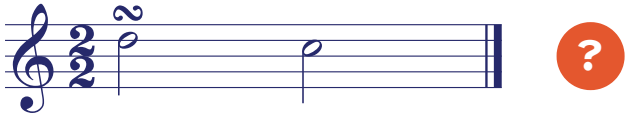


1. **Look for the slash** through the tiny note.
2. **With a slash:** how fast?
3. **Without:** how much time does it take?

Slash (acciaccatura): **crushed in**, almost at once. No slash (appoggiatura): **D for a crotchet**, then C.

EXAMPLE 3

Which notes does the turn use?



1. **The main note** is D.
2. **Next door above**, and **next door below**?
3. **Order:** above, main, below, main.

E D C D, then hold the D: four quick notes, ending on the main note.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS



A slow trill.

Play D and E with fingers 2 and 3, slowly, eight times. Then a little faster. A trill is just that, at speed, with the beat still steady.

HOW TO

Practise an ornament

1. **Play the main notes** alone first, in time.
2. **Add the ornament slowly**, as written-out notes.
3. **Speed it up** bit by bit, keeping the main note on the beat.

TRAP

- × Adding a sharp or flat that is not there: use the plain next-door letter.
- × Starting the ornament late: it begins on the beat (a crushed note just before it).

SEE ALSO
The keyboard p. 22 · Sharps and flats p. 39

PRACTISE IT
Online: Library › Ornaments

PART III · EXPRESSION · TIPS

When your playing sounds flat

Every note can be right and the music still sound flat. The fix is almost always one sign you read but did not play. Find what you notice, then check that one thing.

TIP

What you notice, what to check

WHAT YOU NOTICE	CHECK	TURN TO
Everything is the same loudness	**the dynamics:** is every sign a different step?	p. 76
The tune sounds choppy	**the slurs:** join every note inside the curve	p. 79
Short notes sound heavy	**staccato** is short, not loud	p. 79
The end feels rushed	**rit. and fermata:** slow little by little, then wait	p. 82
The sound is muddy	**the pedal:** change on each new chord	p. 85
The ornament trips the beat	**the main note** lands on time; practise it slowly	p. 88

Four ways to bring music to life

1. **Sing it first**
   Sing the phrase: your voice shapes it naturally. Then copy your voice on the keys.
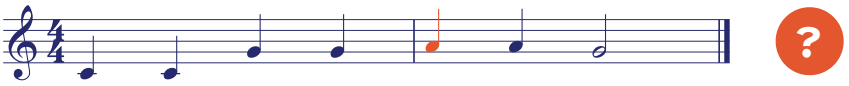
2. **Exaggerate**
   Play the dynamics twice as big as you think. It always sounds smaller to the listener.

3. **Record yourself**
   Listen back with the music: did each sign really happen?

4. **Shape every phrase**
   Grow towards the most important note, then let the phrase fall away.

EXAMPLE

Give this phrase a shape



?

1. **Sing it:** where does it want to go?
2. **Which note** feels like the top of the hill?
3. **Where** would you start soft and end soft?

Start soft, grow to the first A, then fade: **a phrase is a hill**, up and down.

THINK OF IT Expression is the difference between reading a story aloud and telling it.